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Culture (OWC): [Suku \(FO46\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Central Africa

Field Date: 1958-1959

Coverage Date: 1920 AD - 1970 AD

Place Coverage

Kwango district, Bandundu, Democratic Republic of the Congo

Section Title(S)

Application of Hsu's Formulations to the Suku

One final query: Are there cultural systems that demand greater integration among relationships, and others that minimize the need for consistency? And even when there is a consistency in the structure, how does it affect the actors in it? As a system, Suku kinship structure is rigidly integrated, but the people occupying the various slots in it can be shifted around. For example, a person can shift from the slot of patrilineal cross-cousin (with whom one jokes, and whom, if female, one can marry) to the slot of "father" or "father's sister" (whereupon one stops joking and starts respecting and marriage becomes forbidden). Such shifts reverberate throughout the system. Whole groups of relatives get reclassified terminologically and behavior toward them shifts accordingly, but the system itself remains rigidly consistent. It would seem that the culture here allows a kind of discontinuity of roles in specific persons that another culture would not (for example, from sexual joking to avoidance or *vice versa*). Do relationships in such systems influence each other in the same way as in systems emphasizing a different kind of integration? What happens in systems where relationships are essentially dyadic and treated atomistically? The questions concern something anthropologists have yet to tackle, namely the effect of the cultural conceptions of how it should work on the way an existing system works—in short, the influence of a people's own ethno-sociology on their "objective" sociology.

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